

An interesting empirical study highlights the power of basic biological impulses (in this case, circadian rhythm) on the human mind. Bodenhausen conducts a study highlighting varying degrees of discrimination exhibited by individuals who self-identify as either “morning types” or “evening types.”⁷ Each individual is asked, at different times of the day, to state his opinion on the guiltiness of a suspect associated with an alleged crime. The descriptions of the suspects are purposely stereotyped in a way that should appeal to innate discrimination, thereby triggering System 1 heuristic decision-making.

The author tabulates the results for the perceived guilt by time of day for all participants in the study. [Figure 3.8](#) breaks out the results for the 9:00 a.m. and 8:00 p.m. surveys for both morning and evening types. Morning types were more likely to give a suspect the benefit of the doubt when they were feeling bright and chipper early in the day, but much more likely to view the suspects as guilty when asked later in the day when their minds were wandering. Evening types exhibited the same pattern, but in reverse. Suspects were more likely to be considered guilty by the evening types in the morning, when they were presumably grumpier and less aware, but these same individuals were more lenient on suspects when asked in the evening, during a time when they were feeling more wakeful.